



SQL OF THE DAY

split first

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StrataScratch · #10049

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THE PROBLEM

Find the total number of reviews for each business category. Return the category name and total review count, ordered highest to lowest.

one string, many categories...

Medium · PostgreSQL

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THE SOLUTION

```
WITH split_category AS (  
    SELECT UNNEST(  
        STRING_TO_ARRAY(categories, ';')  
    ) AS category,  
        review_count  
    FROM yelp_business  
)  
SELECT category,  
        SUM(review_count) AS no_of_reviews  
FROM split_category  
GROUP BY 1  
ORDER BY 2 DESC;
```





HOW IT WORKS

SPLIT THE STRING

`STRING_TO_ARRAY(categories, ';')` splits the semicolon string into an array, one element per category.

EXPAND TO ROWS

`UNNEST()` turns the array into rows: a business with three categories becomes three rows, each keeping its `review_count`.

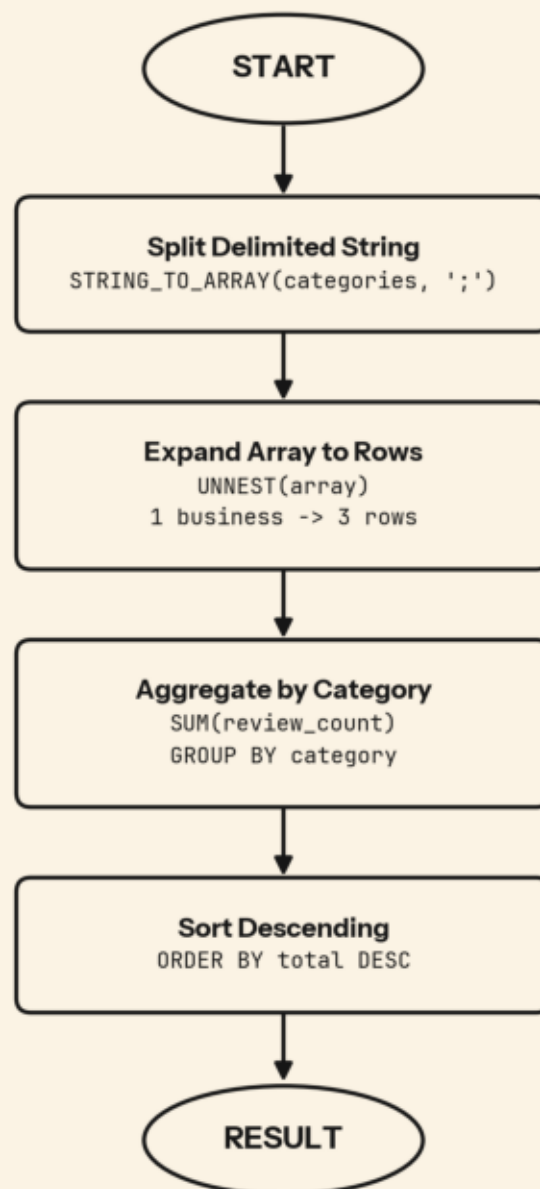
AGGREGATE

`SUM(review_count) GROUP BY category` totals reviews across every exploded row.





THE LOGIC





WHY IT MATTERS

01

Category demand

Totals per category show which segments pull the most engagement, so marketing and partnerships know where to invest.

02

Hidden undercount

A business in three categories should feed all three. Miss the split and your top-category report understates the widest segments.

03

Curation priorities

Categories with low review counts surface where the catalog is thin or mistagged and needs attention.





KEY TAKEAWAYS

- 1 A delimited column miscounts under GROUP BY. Split first, then aggregate.
- 2 STRING_TO_ARRAY builds the array; UNNEST turns it into rows. Two jobs, not interchangeable.
- 3 The same pattern fits tags, roles, genres, and permission sets, not just Yelp.

follow for more SQL problems

questions? nivanrs@gmail.com

